

Perceptions of Profit Motive: How Can Messaging Affect Beliefs about Profit-Seeking

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Bhattacharjee et al. (2017) propose that people tend to hold *anti-profit beliefs*.

Anti-profit beliefs: Perceptions that profit-seeking is necessarily in conflict with beneficial outcomes for society.

We propose that people's pre-existing beliefs about profit may not be fixed. Rather these beliefs may be susceptible to change depending on different messaging.

Research Question: *Can people's perceptions of profit-seeking be influenced by arguments that emphasize either the positive or negative consequences of profit for society?*

Hypothesis 1: *Agreement with profit-related statements depends on whether the negative or positive sides of profit-seeking is emphasized.*

Study 1: Identify the most agreeable anti-profit and pro-profit statements that are based on arguments used by experts

Hypothesis 2: *Perceptions of profit-seeking companies can be affected by exposure to statements that emphasize either the negative or positive sides outcomes of profit.*

Study 2: Measure perceptions of for-profit vs. nonprofit companies depending on exposure to pro-profit vs. anti-profit statements.

Study 1

Methods

Sample size: $n=100$

Design: Random assignment to pro-profit vs. anti-profit conditions

Procedure: Rate statements on an agreement scale ranging from (1= Strongly Disagree to 7=Strongly Agree)

Analysis

Selecting the highest mean score on the agreement scale

Pro-profit statements tap into intuitive beliefs by highlighting *market mechanisms* and *positive-sum beliefs*.

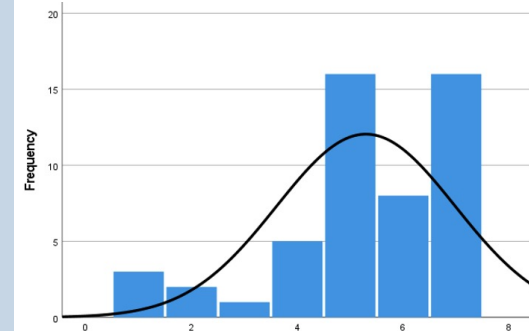
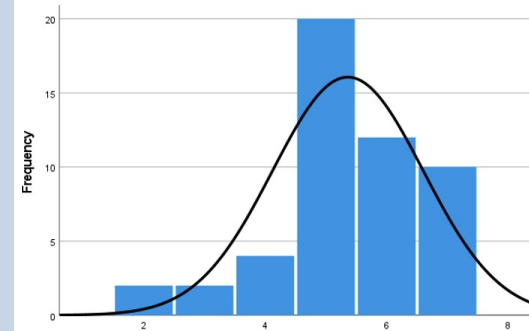
Sample statement: *Maximizing profit motivates companies to build a strong reputation among their employees, suppliers, and customers.* ($M = 5.36$, $SD = 1.24$)

86% of people are above the midpoint on the Agreement scale

Anti-profit statements tap into intuitive beliefs by highlighting *market failures* and *zero-sum beliefs*.

Sample Statement: *Profit-seeking companies can be motivated to raise prices, lower quality, and eliminate competition.* ($M = 5.29$, $SD = 1.68$)

78% of people are above the midpoint on the Agreement scale



People agree with both pro-profit and anti-profit statements depending on which intuitive beliefs are activated by emphasizing the positive or negative side of profit-seeking.

Proposed Study 2

Planned Method

Sample size: $n= 450$

Design: A 3 (between: *anti-profit, pro-profit, neutral statements*) x 2 (within: *for-profit, nonprofit firm types*) **mixed factorial design**

Planned Procedure:

Random assignment to one of the pro-profit, anti-profit and control conditions

Rate for-profit and nonprofit companies on Overall Social Impact

Predicted Results:

Pro-profit condition: For-profits are predicted to be perceived as more socially responsible than anti-profit, and control conditions

Anti-profit condition: For-profits are predicted to be seen as less socially responsible than in pro-profit, and control conditions

Anti-profit beliefs: In the **control condition**, for-profits are predicted to be seen as less socially valuable than nonprofits